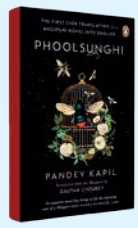
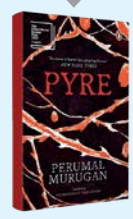


TOMB OF SAND
by Geetanjali Shree; translated by Daisy Rockwell
PENGUIN INDIA
₹699; 696 pages

THE BRIDE
by Harimohan Jha; translated by Lalit Kumar
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA; **₹350; 192** pages



GHACHAR GHOCHAR
by Vivek Shanbhag; translated by Srinath Perur
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹350; 128 pages



PYRE
by Perumal Murugan; translated by Aniruddhan Vasudevan
PENGUIN INDIA
₹250; 224 pages

significant improvement in the quality and quantity of translations," she says. "There are more young translators, more universities are offering Translation Studies. There are more grants and mentorships... Earlier, the focus was on novels, but now, short stories and non-fiction are also being translated. There is also regional diversity in translated literature coming out of India; you'll see titles from Kashmir, from the Northeast."

Another factor in the surge of translated literature in Indian English publishing is the shrinking of the 'midlist'. The term, commonly used within publishing circles, refers to authors and books that fall anywhere between "bestsellers" and "obscure/little-known". Midlist authors typically produce a new book every couple of years, and their books sell a few thousand copies if they're lucky. Accordingly, in economic terms, these are 'break-even' bets for publishers—on a good day, they turn a modest profit or recover their cost of publishing. In rosier times for Indian English publishing, firms would keep investing in midlist authors in a sustained manner, with the hope that some of the midlist will score a mainstream hit eventually. Now, in times of belt-tightening all around, publishers are looking for safe bets and celebrity authors, reducing the midlist further and further.

"The English midlist shrank in a big way over the last five-six years in particular because of low sales," says Thakur. "Beyond a point, publishers simply decided to reduce their investment. The titles that were being brought out were either 'high literary' or mass-market genre books. But publishers still needed fiction, and that's where translated literature (especially from under-translated regions in India) came in."

One of the byproducts of this resurgence in interest around translations is that several important Indian writers who remain strangers to English readers are finally receiving their due. Like the Kannada poet Dattatreya Ramachandra Bendre (1896-1981), some of whose works have recently been translated into English by writer and translator Madhav Ajjampur, in *The Pollen Waits on Tiptoe*. A unique aspect of this publication is that next to every poem-in-translation, there's a QR code that directs readers to a webpage where they can listen to the original Kannada poem as well as the translation being recited by Ajjampur. Sounds are so crucial to the process of translation, after all, and even more so with poetry.

"There's a perception—not wrong, in my opinion—that poetry is the most difficult of all the forms of literature when it comes to translation," says Ajjampur. "Most mainstream publishers bring out a very small number of poetry titles every year, and most of these titles are by well-established Indian English poets. As a result, there's very little scope for poetry books in translation." He adds, "What I would like to see is more translation between different Indian languages.... Right now, if you're a bhasha writer hoping to be recognised around the country or even globally, your best chance is to be translated into English. I want to see Indian readers discovering bhasha writing from cultures that are not their own." ■

Aditya Mani Jha



ANIMAL ACADEMY
Rainforest Rescue
by Riah Rajani
WONDER HOUSE BOOKS; **₹199; 240** pages

Animal Academy: Rainforest Rescue can inspire children to harness their own creative juices. The book, following young Emily and her beloved horse Thunder at the titular Animal Academy, has been written by 10-year-old Mumbai schoolkid Riah Rajani. The story sees Emily and her horse pal investigating mysterious occurrences at the Animal Academy. Gorgeously illustrated, the book is recommended for *Harry Potter* fans.



ELEPHANTAM MISOPHANTAM
by Vinoy Thomas; translated by Nandakumar K.
EKA/WESTLAND BOOKS; **₹120; 250** pages

In *Elephantam Misophantam*, Vinoy Thomas cleverly unfurls an eco-fable within an adventure story. The narrative begins with the capture of Lightning Tusker, an intrepid elephant. How his clan, led by Tuskless Tusker, rescue Lightning forms the crux of the story, allowing Thomas to give readers the larger picture, "...the catch-me-if-you-can game that goes on between the elephants in the wild and the men from the hamlet".

Aditya Mani Jha